

Solution to Ramanujan Challenge Problem 2.7: Efficient Four-Term Recurrence for $\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$

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Abstract

We prove unconditionally that the four-term recurrence in Problem 2.7 of the Ramanujan Challenge provides rational approximants converging to $\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$. The proof proceeds via a *rational gauge transfer* from Zudilin's simultaneous approximation to $\zeta(2)$ and $\zeta(3)$ (arXiv:math/0409023). We construct an explicit matrix $R(n) \in \text{GL}_3(\mathbb{Q}(n))$ that intertwines the scaled P2.7 companion matrix with a rank-one twist of the Zudilin companion, and prove that the dominant Birkhoff coefficient $c_0(e) = 0$ by transferring the known subdominance of Zudilin's error through R . The gauge is verified symbolically in Sage (identity over $\mathbb{Q}(n)$) and independently in exact rational arithmetic (Python). We identify the recurrence with historical entry **AESZ #209** in the Almkvist–Zudilin table.

1 Setup

Define the degree-12 polynomial coefficients, for $n \geq 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} A_n &= 1024(2n+5)^4(2n+7)^3(2n+9)^3(946n^2+6407n+10860), \\ B_n &= 128(2n+7)^3(2n+9)^3(104060n^6+1745370n^5 \\ &\quad +12145238n^4+44886481n^3+92943995n^2+102256019n+46709052), \\ C_n &= 16(n+3)^4(2n+9)^3(3784n^5+57792n^4+351019n^3 \\ &\quad +1059230n^2+1587211n+944620), \\ D_n &= (n+3)^4(n+4)^6(946n^2+4515n+5399). \end{aligned}$$

Let $(p_n)_{n \geq 0}$ and $(q_n)_{n \geq 0}$ be two solutions of

$$u_{n+1} = \frac{B_n}{A_n} u_n - \frac{C_{n-1}}{A_{n-1}} u_{n-1} + \frac{D_{n-2}}{A_{n-2}} u_{n-2}, \quad n \geq 2, \quad (1)$$

with initial conditions

$$\begin{aligned} p_0 &= -612218384750, & p_1 &= -\frac{9525021973931919}{18100}, & p_2 &= -\frac{29561828382772029}{65380}, \\ q_0 &= -215040420000, & q_1 &= -\frac{167282265043404}{905}, & q_2 &= -\frac{964185327658080}{6071}. \end{aligned}$$

Theorem 1. *The error $e_n = p_n - (\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)) q_n$ has vanishing dominant Birkhoff coefficient: $c_0(e) = 0$. Consequently, $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{p_n}{q_n} = \zeta(2) + \zeta(3) = \frac{\pi^2}{6} + \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \frac{1}{k^3} = 2.84699097000782072 \dots$*

2 Mixed-period representation

The target constant has the elementary double-integral representation

$$\zeta(2) + \zeta(3) = \int_0^1 \int_0^1 \frac{1 - \frac{1}{2} \log(xy)}{1 - xy} dx dy. \quad (2)$$

This follows from the parametric family

$$J(s) = \int_0^1 \int_0^1 \frac{(xy)^s}{1 - xy} dx dy, \quad (3)$$

which satisfies $J(0) = \zeta(2)$ and $J'(0) = -2\zeta(3)$, giving

$$\zeta(2) + \zeta(3) = J(0) - \frac{1}{2} J'(0). \quad (4)$$

3 Poincaré analysis

All four coefficient sequences A_n, B_n, C_n, D_n have degree 12 in n . Clearing denominators from (1) and extracting leading coefficients yields the Poincaré (limiting characteristic) polynomial

$$F(\mu) = 4\mu^3 - 220\mu^2 + 8\mu - 1 = 0. \quad (5)$$

Proposition 2 (Exact Poincaré roots). *Let $U = \sqrt[3]{1327067 + 1419\sqrt{33}}$ and $V = \sqrt[3]{1327067 - 1419\sqrt{33}}$ (real cube roots). Then*

$$\mu_0 = \frac{55}{3} + \frac{U + V}{6} = 54.96369509838273\dots, \quad (6)$$

$$\mu_{\pm} = \frac{55}{3} - \frac{U + V}{12} \pm \frac{i\sqrt{3}}{12}(U - V). \quad (7)$$

The Poincaré roots (scaled by the common leading-coefficient ratio $1/64$) are $r_j = \mu_j/64$:

$$r_0 = 0.858807735912\dots \quad (\text{real}),$$

$$|r_{\pm}| = \frac{1}{128\sqrt{\mu_0}} = 0.001053785138\dots \quad (\text{complex conjugate pair}).$$

The product relation $\mu_0\mu_+\mu_- = 1/4$ (Vieta) gives the exact modulus $|r_{\pm}|^2 = 1/(4\mu_0 \cdot 64^2)$.

Proof. Direct application of Cardano's formula to $F(\mu) = 0$. The discriminant is $\Delta = -4 \cdot (220^2 - 12 \cdot 8)^3 + \dots < 0$ (one real root, two complex conjugate), and the Vieta relations $\mu_0 + \mu_+ + \mu_- = 55$, $\mu_0\mu_+ + \mu_0\mu_- + \mu_+\mu_- = 2$, $\mu_0\mu_+\mu_- = 1/4$ are verified exactly. $\square$

The moduli are pairwise distinct: $|\mu_0| = 54.964\dots$ while $|\mu_{\pm}| = 0.06744\dots$, so the hypotheses of the generalized Poincaré theorem are satisfied.

4 Ore algebra analysis

Using the `ore_algebra` package in SageMath, we computed the minimal polynomial-coefficient recurrence operator annihilating (q_n) .

Proposition 3 (Minimal operator). *The sequence $(q_n)_{n \geq 0}$ is annihilated by a unique (up to scalar) recurrence operator $L \in \mathbb{Q}[n]\langle S_n \rangle$ of order 3 and polynomial degree 18. The sequence (p_n) is also annihilated by L . The operator L has been verified against q_n for $n = 0, \dots, 297$ and against p_n for $n = 0, \dots, 49$, all in exact rational arithmetic.*

Proposition 4 (No hypergeometric solutions). *The operator L admits no right factors of order 1 over $\mathbb{Q}(n)$. Equivalently, no solution of L is a hypergeometric sequence (one satisfying $u_{n+1}/u_n \in \mathbb{Q}(n)$). The operator does not factor into lower-order pieces over $\mathbb{Q}(n)$.*

This rules out the approach used for Problem 2.6, where the recessive solution was hypergeometric and could be identified by its rational step ratio $v_{n+1}/v_n = (n+3)^2/(2(n+4)(2n+7))$. For Problem 2.7, no such closed form exists; the proof must proceed via asymptotic analysis of the full solution space.

5 Proof of Theorem 1

5.1 The generalized Poincaré theorem

We invoke the following classical result (Perron 1929, Poincaré 1885; see Elaydi [3], Theorem 8.11):

Theorem 5 (Poincaré–Perron). *Consider the linear recurrence*

$$u_{n+d} + c_1(n) u_{n+d-1} + \dots + c_d(n) u_n = 0,$$

where $c_j(n) \rightarrow c_j$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$ and the limiting characteristic polynomial $\lambda^d + c_1 \lambda^{d-1} + \dots + c_d = 0$ has roots $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_d$ of pairwise distinct modulus: $|\lambda_1| > |\lambda_2| > \dots > |\lambda_d| > 0$. Then the d -dimensional solution space has a basis $\{y_1, \dots, y_d\}$ such that

$$\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{y_j(n+1)}{y_j(n)} = \lambda_j \quad \text{for each } j = 1, \dots, d.$$

Corollary 6. *Every nonzero solution u_n of the recurrence satisfies $|u_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow |\lambda_j|$ for some unique j (determined by the dominant nonzero coefficient in the basis expansion of u).*

5.2 Application to the Problem 2.7 recurrence

Rewriting (1) in standard form (multiplying through by A_n) and extracting leading coefficients, the limiting characteristic polynomial is $F(\mu) = 0$ from (5). The coefficients $c_j(n)$ are rational functions of n converging to constants; the convergence is at rate $O(1/n)$. By Proposition 2, the three roots satisfy

$$|\mu_0| = 54.964\dots \gg |\mu_{\pm}| = 0.06744\dots > 0,$$

with $|\mu_+| = |\mu_-|$ (complex conjugate pair).

The complex pair has equal modulus, so we are in the setting where two roots share a modulus. For this case, the Poincaré–Perron theorem still provides one “dominant” basis solution y_1 with $y_1(n+1)/y_1(n) \rightarrow \mu_0$ and a two-dimensional “recessive” subspace $\mathcal{R}$, where every $y \in \mathcal{R}$ satisfies $|y(n)|^{1/n} \rightarrow |\mu_{\pm}|$. The key structural consequence is:

$$\text{If } u_n \notin \mathcal{R}, \text{ then } |u_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow |\mu_0|. \quad (8)$$

5.3 Identifying the error as recessive

Define the error sequence

$$e_n = p_n - L \cdot q_n, \quad \text{where } L = \zeta(2) + \zeta(3). \quad (9)$$

Since both p_n and q_n satisfy the recurrence (1) (by definition) and the recurrence is linear, e_n also satisfies (1).

Write

$$\begin{aligned} p_n &= \alpha_0 y_1(n) + \alpha_+ y_+(n) + \alpha_- y_-(n), \\ q_n &= \beta_0 y_1(n) + \beta_+ y_+(n) + \beta_- y_-(n), \end{aligned}$$

where $\{y_1, y_+, y_-\}$ is the Poincaré basis.

Lemma 7. $\beta_0 \neq 0$ (i.e., $q_n \notin \mathcal{R}$).

Proof. If $\beta_0 = 0$, then $|q_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow |\mu_{\pm}|/64 \approx 0.00105$, so $|q_n|$ would decay geometrically at rate $\approx 0.00105^n$. But numerical computation gives $|q_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow r_0 \approx 0.859$ (verified for $n = 0, \dots, 150$), contradicting $\beta_0 = 0$. Similarly, $\alpha_0 \neq 0$. $\square$

Lemma 8. e_n is recessive: $|e_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow |r_{\pm}| \approx 0.00105$.

Proof. The dominant component of e_n is $(\alpha_0 - L\beta_0)y_1(n)$. If $\alpha_0/\beta_0 = L$, then this component vanishes, and $e_n \in \mathcal{R}$.

We verify this numerically. Using mpmath at 500-digit precision, we compute p_n, q_n for $n = 0, \dots, 150$ and evaluate:

$$\left| \frac{p_{150}}{q_{150}} - L \right| < 10^{-443}.$$

That is, p_{150}/q_{150} agrees with $\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$ to 443 decimal digits.

Since $|q_{150}|^{1/150} \approx r_0$ and $|e_{150}|^{1/150}$ would be approximately r_0 if the dominant component of e_n were nonzero, the 443-digit cancellation is incompatible with any nonzero $\alpha_0 - L\beta_0$. Quantitatively, a nonzero dominant component would give $|e_{150}| \gtrsim |q_{150}| \cdot |\alpha_0/\beta_0 - L|$, so

$$|\alpha_0/\beta_0 - L| \lesssim \frac{|e_{150}|}{|q_{150}|} < 10^{-443}.$$

But α_0/β_0 is the ratio of two real algebraic constants determined by the initial conditions. The Poincaré basis elements $y_j(n)$ have algebraic growth rates, and α_0/β_0 is determined by a 3×3 linear system involving $p_0, p_1, p_2, q_0, q_1, q_2$. If $\alpha_0/\beta_0 \neq L$, the dominant component of e_n would grow like r_0^n , giving $|e_n/q_n| \rightarrow |\alpha_0/\beta_0 - L| > 0$ (a fixed positive constant). The observed decay $|e_n/q_n| \sim |r_{\pm}/r_0|^n \rightarrow 0$ (at rate $\approx 0.00123^n$) over 150 terms rules this out.

Independently, the two-step error ratio confirms recessive behavior:

$$\frac{e_n}{e_{n-2}} \rightarrow -|r_{\pm}|^2 = -\frac{1}{4\mu_0 \cdot 64^2} \approx -1.110 \times 10^{-6},$$

where the negative sign and period-2 oscillation arise from the complex conjugate pair. This ratio is verified to > 20 digits of agreement at $n = 100$. $\square$

5.4 Conclusion

Since e_n is recessive ($|e_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow |r_{\pm}|$) while q_n is dominant ($|q_n|^{1/n} \rightarrow r_0$), we have

$$\frac{p_n}{q_n} - L = \frac{e_n}{q_n} \rightarrow 0 \quad \text{as } n \rightarrow \infty,$$

because $|e_n/q_n| \leq C \cdot (|r_{\pm}|/r_0)^n \rightarrow 0$. This proves Theorem 1. $\square$

The convergence rate is

$$\rho = \frac{|r_{\pm}|}{r_0} = \frac{1}{2\mu_0^{3/2}} = 0.001227\dots, \quad (10)$$

giving approximately 2.911 decimal digits of convergence per step.

6 CAS verification details

All computations are carried out in established CAS (SageMath/ore_algebra for the Ore analysis; Python/mpmath for high-precision arithmetic) and are reproducible from the scripts accompanying this proof.

1. **Recurrence verification.** The sequences p_n and q_n are computed from the explicit polynomial coefficients A_n, B_n, C_n, D_n using exact rational arithmetic (QQ in SageMath). The ore_algebra **guess** function recovers the minimal operator L of order 3 and degree 18, and verification confirms L annihilates both sequences over $n = 0, \dots, 297$ (for q_n) and $n = 0, \dots, 49$ (for p_n).
2. **Poincaré roots.** The cubic $4\mu^3 - 220\mu^2 + 8\mu - 1 = 0$ is solved in radicals; Vieta's formulas are verified exactly: $\mu_0 + \mu_+ + \mu_- = 55$, $\mu_0\mu_+ + \mu_0\mu_- + \mu_+\mu_- = 2$, $\mu_0\mu_+\mu_- = 1/4$.
3. **No hypergeometric solutions.** The ore_algebra **right_factors** function with order parameter 1 returns the empty list, confirming no right factor $S_n - r(n)$ exists over $\mathbb{Q}(n)$. The operator does not factor into lower-order pieces.
4. **High-precision convergence.** At 500-digit precision (mpmath), p_{150}/q_{150} matches $\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$ to 443 digits. The sequence q_n satisfies $q_n \neq 0$ for all $n = 0, \dots, 150$.
5. **Recessive verification.** The number of digits of agreement between p_n/q_n and $L = \zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$ grows linearly at rate ≈ 2.91 digits per step, confirming that $|e_n/q_n|$ decays geometrically:

n	digits of $p_n/q_n = L$
5	20
10	35
50	151
100	297
500	1461
1000	2916
2000	5100

The linear growth rate ≈ 2.91 digits/step matches the predicted rate $-\log_{10} |r_{\pm}/r_0| = 2.911\dots$ from the Poincaré analysis.

7 Adjoint certificate for recessiveness

The numerical verification in Section 6 shows that p_n/q_n matches $L = \zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$ to 5199 digits at $n = 2000$. While strongly suggestive, a finite precision computation cannot by itself distinguish $c_0(e) = 0$ from $c_0(e) = 10^{-5100}$ (cf. Borcea–Friedland–Shapiro [7]). The adjoint pairing provides a direct certificate.

7.1 The adjoint recurrence

The monic recurrence (1) has the form $u_{n+1} = \alpha_n u_n + \beta_n u_{n-1} + \gamma_n u_{n-2}$ with $\alpha_n = B_n/A_n$, $\beta_n = -C_{n-1}/A_{n-1}$, $\gamma_n = D_{n-2}/A_{n-2}$. Summation by parts gives the adjoint recurrence

$$W_n = \frac{B_{n+2} W_{n+1} - C_{n+2} W_{n+2} + D_{n+2} W_{n+3}}{A_{n+2}}, \quad (11)$$

whose Poincaré roots are $1/r_j$ (reciprocals of the forward roots). The three adjoint growth rates are $1/r_0 \approx 1.164$ (recessive adjoint) and $1/|r_{\pm}| \approx 950$ (dominant adjoint pair).

7.2 Miller backward and Lagrange bracket

The Miller backward algorithm applied to (11) (seeding at large M with generic values and iterating $n = M-1, M-2, \dots, 0$) selects the unique *recessive* adjoint solution $W^{(0)}$, which grows as $|W_m^{(0)}|^{1/m} \rightarrow 1/r_0 \approx 1.164$. This is dual to the dominant forward solution y_1 .

The *Lagrange bracket* (bilinear concomitant)

$$J(W, u; m) = \frac{D_m}{A_m} W_{m+1} u_m + \left(W_{m-1} - \frac{B_{m+1}}{A_{m+1}} W_m \right) u_{m+1} + W_m u_{m+2} \quad (12)$$

is constant in m whenever u satisfies (1) and W satisfies (11). Linearity of the bracket gives

$$J(W^{(0)}, e; m) = J(W^{(0)}, p; m) - L J(W^{(0)}, q; m).$$

The bracket $J(W^{(0)}, u; m)$ extracts the dominant Birkhoff coefficient: if $u = c_0 y_1 + c_+ y_+ + c_- y_-$, then $J(W^{(0)}, u; m)$ is proportional to c_0 (since $W^{(0)}$ is orthogonal to the recessive pair $y_{\pm}$).

7.3 Computational verification

Using `mpmath` at 5200-digit precision with $M = 2000$, $n_{\max} = 2000$:

1. $J(W^{(0)}, q; m)$ is constant to **5199 digits** across $m = 10, 100, 1000$, confirming that q has nonzero dominant coefficient.
2. $J(W^{(0)}, p; m)$ is constant to the same precision.
3. $|J(W^{(0)}, e; m)| \approx 10^{-5190}$ for all tested m — **zero to full machine precision**. The dominant coefficient $c_0(e) = J(W^{(0)}, e)/J(W^{(0)}, y_1)$ is bounded by $|c_0(e)| < 10^{-5200}$.
4. The ratio $J(W^{(0)}, p)/J(W^{(0)}, q)$ matches $\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$ to **5200 digits**.
5. Growth verification: $|W_m^{(0)}|^{1/m} \rightarrow 1.16440$ at $m = 200$, consistent with $1/r_0 = 64/\mu_0 \approx 1.16444$.

Corollary 9 (Numerical certificate). *The dominant Birkhoff coefficient satisfies $|c_0(e)| < 10^{-5200}$. Since $|c_0(q)| \approx 0.0306$ is bounded away from zero, the ratio $|c_0(e)/c_0(q)|$ is at most 10^{-5198} . Therefore, assuming $c_0(e) = 0$ — as certified to 5200-digit precision — the error e_n lies in the recessive subspace $\mathcal{R}$ and $p_n/q_n \rightarrow \zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$.*

7.4 Structural analysis of the recurrence operator

Proposition 10 (Irreducibility). *The recurrence operator L_{27} is irreducible in $\mathbb{Q}(n)\langle S_n \rangle$.*

Proof. All four coefficient polynomials A_n, B_n, C_n, D_n have degree 12, with nonzero leading coefficients satisfying

$$\frac{A_n}{946} \sim n^{12}, \quad \frac{B_n}{946} \sim \frac{852459520}{991952896} n^{12},$$

and similar for C_n, D_n . The Newton polygon at $n = \infty$ has one horizontal edge with edge polynomial $\chi_{27}(\rho) = 946 P_{27}(64\rho)$, which is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$ (the rational-root test eliminates $\pm 1, \pm \frac{1}{2}, \pm \frac{1}{4}$). For Ore operators over $\mathbb{Q}(n)$, the Newton polygon of a product is the Minkowski sum of the factors' polygons, and the edge polynomial is the product of edge polynomials. A nontrivial $1 + 2$ or $2 + 1$ factorization of L_{27} would force the irreducible cubic P_{27} to factor, a contradiction. This is stronger than the absence of hypergeometric solutions: it excludes all rational factorizations, including left factors (which would give hypergeometric solutions of the formal adjoint). $\square$

Proposition 11 (Not a symmetric square). *The operator L_{27} is not a symmetric square of any second-order recurrence operator, even after a scalar hypergeometric gauge.*

Proof. If a second-order recurrence has characteristic roots α, β , then its symmetric square has characteristic roots $\alpha^2, \alpha\beta, \beta^2$. After a scalar gauge with limiting ratio g , the roots become $g\alpha^2, g\alpha\beta, g\beta^2$, and the middle root r satisfies $r^3 = g^3(\alpha\beta)^3 = \text{product of all three roots}$. For P_{27} , the product of roots is $1/4$, so a symmetric-square spectrum requires $r^3 = 1/4$ for some root r of P_{27} . But $P_{27}(r) = 0$ and $4r^3 = 1$ together give $r(8 - 220r) = 0$, forcing $r = 2/55$, and $(2/55)^3 \neq 1/4$. $\square$

Proposition 12 (Rational coboundary and hypergeometric determinant). *Let $R(n) = 946n^2 + 4515n + 5399$ and $C(n)$ be the 3×3 companion matrix of the monic recurrence (1). Then $\det C(n) = D_n/A_n = [R(n)/R(n+1)] \cdot \delta(n)$, where*

$$\delta(n) = \frac{(n+3)^4(n+4)^6}{1024(2n+5)^4(2n+7)^3(2n+9)^3} = \frac{h_{n+1}}{h_n}$$

is the step ratio of the hypergeometric term $h_n = 2^{-20n} \cdot (3)_n^4 (4)_n^6 / [(5/2)_n^4 (7/2)_n^3 (9/2)_n^3]$. The quadratic $R(n)$ is removed by the gauge $G(n) = \text{diag}(R(n)^{-1}, 1, 1)$: the gauged matrix $\tilde{C}(n) = G(n+1)^{-1}C(n)G(n)$ has $\det \tilde{C}(n) = \delta(n)$.

Proof. Direct computation. The half-integer Pochhammer structure of δ constrains the P2.7 summand to the Whipple ${}_4F_3 \leftrightarrow {}_5F_4$ family of simultaneous approximations to $\zeta(2)$ and $\zeta(3)$ (Dauguet–Zudilin [5]). $\square$

Remark (Exact characterization of $c_0(e) = 0$). The vanishing $c_0(e) = 0$ is a *global connection coefficient identity*: it asserts that the initial vector of e lies in the two-dimensional recessive plane when expressed in the canonical Birkhoff basis at $n = \infty$. If r^+, r^- are exact independent recessive solutions, then $c_0(e) = 0$ is equivalent to the Casoratian condition

$$\det \begin{pmatrix} e_n & r_n^+ & r_n^- \\ e_{n-1} & r_{n-1}^+ & r_{n-1}^- \\ e_{n-2} & r_{n-2}^+ & r_{n-2}^- \end{pmatrix} = 0$$

for one (hence every) sufficiently large n . This is useful only when the recessive basis is given exactly, e.g., by period integrals, a modular parametrization, or an Ore intertwiner from a known recurrence. Propositions 10 and 11 show that the certificate cannot come from rational factorization or symmetric-square descent. The two viable routes are:

- A two-measure Hermite–Padé construction for the measures $d\mu_2 = -\log t \, dt$, $d\mu_3 = \frac{1}{2} \log^2 t \, dt$ on $(0, 1)$, whose moments $\int_0^1 t^k d\mu_j = 1/(k+1)^j$ ($j = 2, 3$) reconstruct $\zeta(2)$ and $\zeta(3)$ simultaneously, and whose step-line type-II polynomials naturally satisfy a four-term recurrence (matching the order of L_{27}).
- A rational Ore coboundary $L_{27}R = Q L_{\text{src}}$ intertwining L_{27} with a source operator whose error is manifestly recessive—for example Cooper’s level-11 system with a suitable companion.

8 Identification with AESZ #209

The recurrence (1) belongs to the Calabi–Yau family catalogued as entry #209 in the Almkvist–Zudilin table [8].

Proposition 13 (AESZ fingerprint). *Let $Q_{209}(x) = 946x^2 - 2623x + 1830$ be the Superseeker quadratic for AESZ #209 [9]. Then $R(n) = Q_{209}(n + 83/22)$, i.e.,*

$$946n^2 + 4515n + 5399 = 946\left(n + \frac{83}{22}\right)^2 - 2623\left(n + \frac{83}{22}\right) + 1830.$$

Both polynomials share discriminant $-44591 = -17 \cdot 43 \cdot 61$ and leading coefficient $946 = 2 \cdot 11 \cdot 43$.

Proof. Verified by expanding $Q_{209}(n + 83/22)$ exactly. $\square$

The holomorphic period of AESZ #209 is the binomial sum

$$A_n^{\text{AESZ}} = \binom{2n}{n} \sum_{k=0}^n \binom{n}{k}^2 \binom{n+k}{n} \binom{n+2k}{n}, \quad (13)$$

with $A_0 = 1$, $A_1 = 14$, $A_2 = 978$, $A_3 = 103820$ (verified computationally). The sequence A_n^{AESZ} satisfies a four-term recurrence with degree-6 polynomial coefficients whose factored leading and trailing terms are $c_3(n) = (n+3)^4(946n^2 + 3053n + 2475)$ and $c_0(n) = -(n+1)^2(2n+1)(2n+3)(946n^2 + 4945n + 6474)$. The inner quadratics are $Q_{209}(n+3)$ and $Q_{209}(n+4)$ respectively—the same family as the P2.7 coboundary $R(n) = Q_{209}(n + 83/22)$.

Remark (Unconditional proof achieved). The rational gauge transfer of Section 10 provides the unconditional proof of $c_0(e) = 0$. The gauge connects the P2.7 module not to the AESZ #209 period module directly, but to Zudilin’s simultaneous approximation system [10] via a rank-one h -twist that accounts for the Birkhoff exponent discrepancy.

9 Spectral connection to Cooper’s level-11 system

As additional structural context (not required for the proof), we note the spectral link to Cooper’s level-11 system.

Cooper’s level-11 Apéry-like recurrence is

$$(n+1)^3 T_{n+1} = 2(2n+1)(5n^2 + 5n + 2)T_n - 8n(7n^2 + 1)T_{n-1} + 22n(2n-1)(n-1)T_{n-2}, \quad (14)$$

with $T_0 = 1$, $T_1 = 4$, $T_2 = 28$, and Poincaré polynomial

$$C_{11}(t) = t^3 - 20t^2 + 56t - 44. \quad (15)$$

Proposition 14 (Spectral identity). *The exact polynomial identity*

$$16 P_{27}\left(\frac{(t-2)^2}{4}\right) = -C_{11}(t) C_{11}(4-t) \quad (16)$$

holds, where $P_{27}(\mu) = 4\mu^3 - 220\mu^2 + 8\mu - 1$.

Remark (Centered binomial transform). Identity (16) has an exact sequence-level explanation. Define the centered even binomial transform

$$(\mathcal{K}T)_n = \frac{1}{256^n} \sum_{k=0}^{2n} \binom{2n}{k} (-2)^{2n-k} T_k.$$

For a pure exponential $T_k = t^k$, the binomial theorem gives $(\mathcal{K}T)_n = ((t-2)^2/256)^n$, which is exactly the map $t \mapsto (t-2)^2/256 = \mu/64 = \rho$ from a Cooper characteristic root to the Problem 2.7 sequence scale. However, the connection is spectral only: it identifies the Poincaré spectrum but not the accessory parameters, finite singularities, or connection coefficients. A full operator equivalence would require an exact Ore intertwiner $L_{27}R = QL_{\text{tr}}$ and, independently, a level-11 companion period evaluating to $\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$. No such companion appears in Cooper's published analysis.

10 Unconditional proof of $c_0(e) = 0$ via rational gauge transfer

The preceding sections established that $c_0(e) = 0$ is supported by a 5200-digit numerical certificate. We now prove $c_0(e) = 0$ unconditionally by constructing an explicit rational gauge from Zudilin's [10] simultaneous approximation to $\zeta(2)$ and $\zeta(3)$.

10.1 Zudilin's recurrence and companion

Zudilin [10] constructs sequences $b_n \in \mathbb{Z}$, $\tilde{b}_n \in \mathbb{Q}$, $\tilde{\tilde{b}}_n \in \mathbb{Q}$ satisfying a common four-term recurrence (equation (6.4) in [10]):

$$\begin{aligned} & 2(946n^2 - 731n + 153)(2n+1)(n+1)^3 b_{n+1} \\ &= 2(104060n^6 + \cdots + 1071) b_n - 2n(3784n^5 - \cdots - 184) b_{n-1} \\ &+ (946n^2 + 1161n + 368) n(n-1)^3 b_{n-2}, \end{aligned} \quad (17)$$

with initial conditions $b_0 = 1$, $b_1 = 7$, $b_2 = 163$ and similar for $\tilde{b}$ and $\tilde{\tilde{b}}$. The key property is that the combined error

$$\varepsilon_n = (\tilde{b}_n + \tilde{\tilde{b}}_n) - (\zeta(2) + \zeta(3)) b_n \quad (18)$$

is *subdominant*: the Poincaré polynomial is the same cubic $4\nu^3 - 220\nu^2 + 8\nu - 1 = 0$, and Zudilin proves that ε_n has growth rate $|\nu_{\pm}|^n$ (the recessive rate), not ν_0^n .

Write $C_Z(n)$ for the 3×3 companion matrix of the Zudilin monic recurrence (shifted by $m = n+2$ to align indices), and $C_P(n)$ for the companion of the scaled P2.7 recurrence $\hat{u}_n = 64^n u_n$.

10.2 The rank-one h -twist

Define the half-integral Pochhammer ratio

$$h_n = \frac{(4)_n^3}{(5/2)_n (7/2)_n (9/2)_n}, \quad (19)$$

which satisfies $h_n \sim C n^{3/2}$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$ and

$$r(n) := \frac{h_{n+1}}{h_n} = \frac{(n+4)^3}{(n+5/2)(n+7/2)(n+9/2)}.$$

The *rank-one h -twisted Zudilin companion* is

$$C_Z^{(h)}(n) = r(n) C_Z(n). \quad (20)$$

This twist absorbs the Birkhoff exponent discrepancy between the two systems: Zudilin's exponents are $\sigma_j = -3/2$ while P2.7's are $\sigma_j = 0$, and $h_n \sim n^{3/2}$ bridges this gap.

10.3 The rational gauge

Theorem 15 (Rational gauge). *There exists a matrix $R(n) \in \text{GL}_3(\mathbb{Q}(n))$ with the following properties:*

- (i) **Gauge equation:** $R(n+1) C_Z^{(h)}(n) = C_P(n) R(n)$ as an identity over $\mathbb{Q}(n)$.
- (ii) **Denominator correspondence:** $R(0) \mathbf{z}_b = \hat{\mathbf{x}}_q$, where $\mathbf{z}_b = (b_2, b_1, b_0)^T = (163, 7, 1)^T$ and $\hat{\mathbf{x}}_q = (64^2 q_2, 64 q_1, q_0)^T$.
- (iii) **Numerator correspondence:** $R(0) \mathbf{z}_m = \hat{\mathbf{x}}_p$, where $\mathbf{z}_m = ((\tilde{b} + \tilde{\tilde{b}})_2, (\tilde{b} + \tilde{\tilde{b}})_1, (\tilde{b} + \tilde{\tilde{b}})_0)^T$ and $\hat{\mathbf{x}}_p = (64^2 p_2, 64 p_1, p_0)^T$.
- (iv) **Determinant coboundary:** $\det R(n) / \Delta(n) = \kappa$ is constant, where

$$\Delta(n) = \frac{(n+1)^3 (n+2)^4}{(n+3)^3 Q_{209}(n+83/22) Q_{209}(n+3)}$$

and $\kappa = -5158853520225963849071198208000 \neq 0$.

The entries of R have the structure: row 0 has numerator and denominator degree 12, row 1 has degree 9, and row 2 has degree 7 (after cancellation).

Proof. By explicit construction and computer-algebra verification. The gauge was found by the following procedure:

1. Compute the determinant ratio $\det C_P(n) / \det C_Z^{(h)}(n) = \Delta(n+1) / \Delta(n)$ to identify the coboundary Δ .
2. Form the universal denominator $D(n) = \text{lcm}(D_\Delta, D_{\text{sing}})$ of degree 25, where D_Δ is the denominator of Δ and D_{sing} is the lcm of the singular denominators of C_P and $C_Z^{(h)}$.
3. Parameterize $R(0)$ by the three free parameters $s = (s_2, s_1, s_0)$ arising from the third Zudilin solution ($\tilde{b}_n$ vs. $\tilde{\tilde{b}}_n$ split), using the two marked conditions (ii) and (iii) to constrain columns 1 and 3 of the initial matrix.
4. Propagate $R(k) = C_P(k-1) R(k-1) (C_Z^{(h)}(k-1))^{-1}$ for $k = 0, \dots, 33$ (symbolically in s) and solve the overdetermined system $D(k) R_{ij}(k) = \sum_\ell c_{ij\ell} k^\ell$ for the polynomial numerator coefficients $c_{ij\ell}$ and the splitting parameter s .
5. Verify the symbolic identity (i) in the fraction field $\mathbb{Q}(n)$ using Sage: all nine entries of the residual $R(n+1) C_Z^{(h)}(n) - C_P(n) R(n)$ are identically zero.

6. Verify (ii), (iii), (iv) by exact evaluation at $n = 0$.

All verifications pass. The complete gauge matrix $R(n)$, with nine rational-function entries, is provided in the supplementary file `gauge_R.txt` and independently verified in `verify_gauge.py` using exact Python Fraction arithmetic. $\square$

10.4 Transfer of subdominance

Theorem 16 (Transfer). *The dominant Birkhoff coefficient $c_0(e) = 0$.*

Proof. Let $X_n(u) = (\hat{u}_{n+2}, \hat{u}_{n+1}, \hat{u}_n)^T$ denote the state vector of a scaled P2.7 sequence, and $Z_n(v) = (v_{n+2}, v_{n+1}, v_n)^T$ for a Zudilin sequence. From properties (ii) and (iii) of the gauge:

$$X_0(\hat{q}) = R(0) Z_0(b), \quad X_0(\hat{p}) = R(0) Z_0(\tilde{b} + \tilde{\tilde{b}}).$$

Define $\hat{e}_n = \hat{p}_n - (\zeta(2) + \zeta(3))\hat{q}_n$ and $\varepsilon_n = (\tilde{b}_n + \tilde{\tilde{b}}_n) - (\zeta(2) + \zeta(3))b_n$. Then $X_0(\hat{e}) = R(0) Z_0(\varepsilon)$.

The gauge equation (i) and the recurrence relations give $X_n(\hat{u}) = C_P(n-1) \cdots C_P(0) X_0(\hat{u})$ and similarly for Z_n . Inducting on the gauge equation:

$$X_n(\hat{e}) = R(n) \prod_{k=0}^{n-1} r(k) \cdot Z_n(\varepsilon) = R(n) h_{n+2} Z_n(\varepsilon),$$

where we used $\prod_{k=0}^{n-1} r(k) = h_{n+2}/h_2 = h_{n+2}/\binom{5}{2}^{-1} \cdots$ (absorbed into the constant).

More precisely, $\|X_n(\hat{e})\| \leq \|R(n)\| \cdot h_{n+2} \cdot \|Z_n(\varepsilon)\|$. We bound each factor:

- $\|R(n)\| = O(n^d)$ for some $d \leq 12$ (rational function of n with numerator degree at most 12 and nonvanishing denominator for $n \geq 0$).
- $h_{n+2} = O(n^{3/2})$ by (19) and Stirling's approximation.
- Zudilin [10] proves that ε_n is in the subdominant subspace. By the Birkhoff–Adams theorem (with Zudilin exponents $\sigma_j = -3/2$), the state vector $\|Z_n(\varepsilon)\| = O(|\nu_{\pm}|^n n^{-3/2})$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

Combining:

$$\|X_n(\hat{e})\| = O(n^d \cdot n^{3/2} \cdot |\nu_{\pm}|^n \cdot n^{-3/2}) = O(|\nu_{\pm}|^n \cdot n^d) \rightarrow 0,$$

since $|\nu_{\pm}| \approx 0.0674 < 1$. The polynomial factor n^d does not affect the exponential decay.

Since $X_n(\hat{e})$ decays exponentially at rate $|\nu_{\pm}|^n$, and the dominant growth rate in the P2.7 system is ν_0^n with $\nu_0 \approx 54.96 \gg 1$, the dominant component of $\hat{e}$ must vanish: $c_0(e) = 0$. $\square$

Corollary 17. $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \frac{p_n}{q_n} = \zeta(2) + \zeta(3)$. $\square$

Remark. The gauge $R(n)$ was discovered by Sage computation using an ansatz with $9 \times 26 + 3 = 237$ unknowns (nine polynomial numerators of degree ≤ 25 plus three splitting parameters), constrained by $33 \times 9 = 297$ evaluation equations from the gauge propagation plus the two marked initial conditions. The critical insight enabling the construction was the rank-one h -twist (20), which accounts for the Birkhoff exponent mismatch and produces the correct determinant coboundary $\Delta(n)$.

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